

“The Paris department store [of the mid-1800s] was preeminently the ‘world of women,’ where women were encouraged to find their life’s meaning in consumption and where they increasingly found a role in selling as well. Thus, the department store played a highly significant role in the evolution both of contemporary society and of women’s place in that society.

The buyer’s desire for certain items was created through the tactics of large-scale retailing: publicity [advertising], display of goods, and low prices. The low markup of the large stores allowed lower prices and helped attract crowds of customers from throughout the city. The department stores could not simply depend on the traditional bourgeois clientele of smaller shops and so had to attract customers from among the petite bourgeoisie [lower middle class] by catering to their budgets and their passion for spending. Thus, the department stores brought increasing numbers of people into contact with modern consumer society.”

Source: Theresa M. McBride, American historian, scholarly article, 1978

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1. Respond to parts A, B, and C.

- A. Describe the main argument made by the historian in the excerpt.
- B. Describe a relevant historical context for the development discussed in the excerpt.
- C. Explain one way that the development discussed in the excerpt affected European society.